

**She came down
from the
mountains**

VOL 2 // THE CRITIQUE

Adri M.

for course GRSJ515 // Winter 2026

SHE CAME DOWN FROM THE MOUNTAINS

VOL. 2, THE CRITIQUE

This volume serves as the analytical anchor for the *She Came Down From the Mountains* project. It provides the academic and theoretical framework for the creative choices made in Volume 1, *The Witness*.

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polivoxia.ca

Available online:



Colophon (v. 1.0.1). 8.5 × 13.13 in saddle-stitched booklet, printed half-size. Set in Atkinson Hyperlegible, with Fraunces on the covers. Black and white only. Typeset in Typst. Imposed with Plica.

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1. INTRODUCTION

The Fragmented Archive and Theory in the Flesh

This project is an attempt to trace and recover a lineage disrupted by colonial displacement. It functions as what I call a *fractured archive*. At first, it was little more than a personal inquiry, but with time it naturally evolved into a study of systemic eliminatory violence (Barakat, 2025). As Amahl Bishara (2025) notes, **“traditions of storytelling are integrally linked to gatherings of commemoration, protest, and resistance”**. By naming this project an *archive*, I am also making an active claim to power. I am asserting that the fragments of the lives I talk about are just as historically significant as the settler-ledgers that tried to erase them.

The choice of the zine as a medium is a deliberate decolonial and transdisciplinary intervention. Zines serve as counter-archives for marginalized communities to record living histories that institutions often deny or erase (Eichhorn, 2013; Licona, 2012). By utilizing a hybrid analog-digital aesthetic, this zine mirrors the archival experience itself: a mixture of fragments, raw traces, and embodied knowledge.

The treatment for this archive is heavily influenced by the radical women of colour in ***This Bridge Called My Back*** (Moraga & Anzaldúa, 1981). The zine performs what Gloria Anzaldúa describes as *theory in the flesh*, where the physical realities of Maruca's indentured servitude and Anita's torture in the Zúñiga Gutiérrez house become the basis for a broader critique of the Costa Rican settler state.

This is also an archive in three voices, each clearly defined in its own colour palette and typography, tracing five generations of women from the land of the Huetar people to Turtle Island. It is intended as a record of resilience that counters the settler-colonial attempt to relegate Indigenous people to a static, prehistoric past. As J. Kēhaulani Kauanui (2025) argues, **“the notion of the Indigenous as static serves all settler colonial states in their attempts to relegate Indigenous people to the past”**.



2. FRAGMENTATION AS FORM

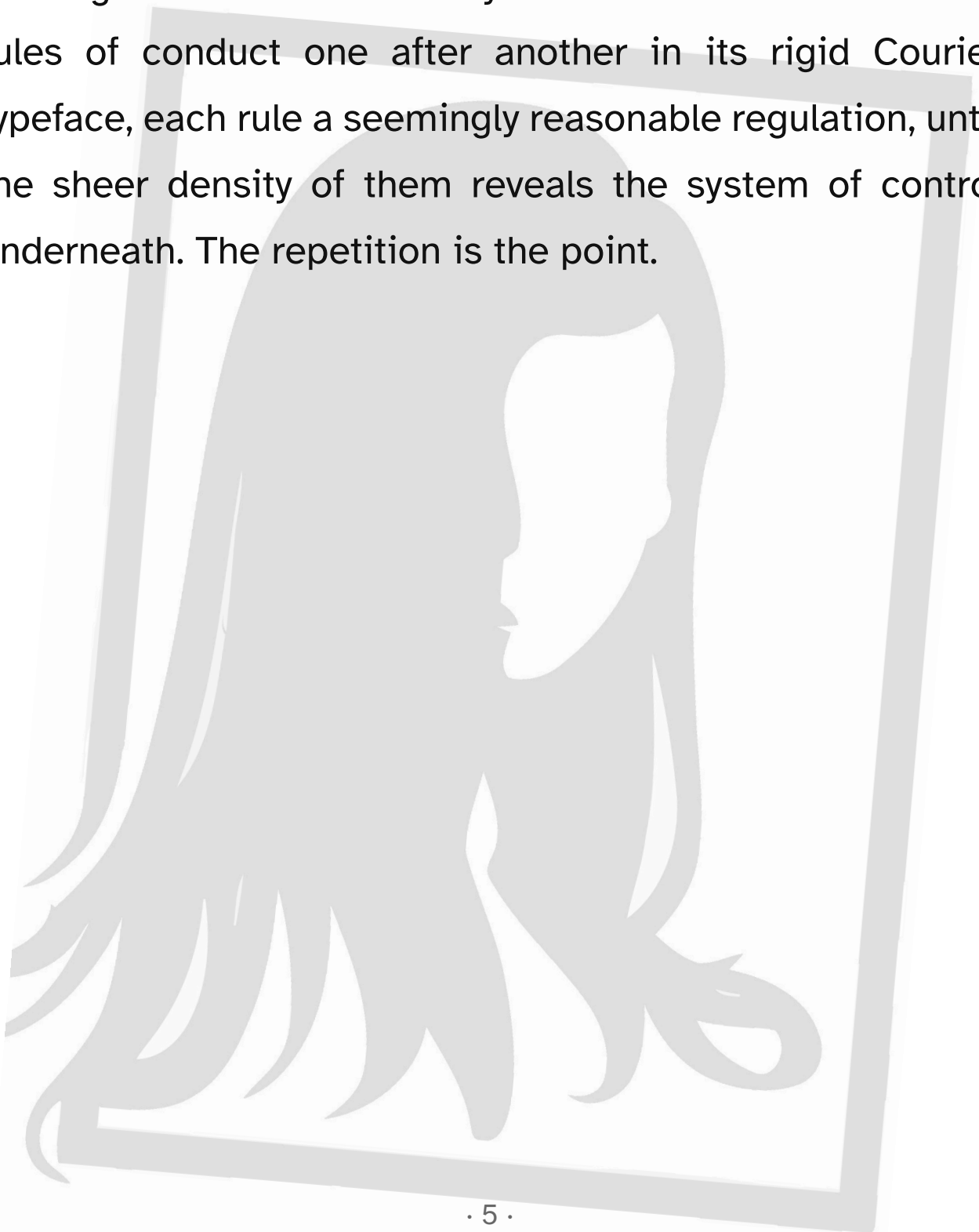
Archival Resistance in *Dictee*

My approach to the zine's layout was inspired by the structural experimentation of Theresa Hak Kyung Cha's ***Dictee*** (2001) and the emotional accumulation of Claudia Rankine's ***Citizen*** (2014), among others. In *Dictee*, the fragmented structure moves between languages and time periods; that fragmented nature takes the void, the spaces that are left empty, and gives them meaning and purpose. In **Volume 1**, this is manifested through the use of text fragments and seemingly disconnected media elements. As I argue in this project, stories don't need to be *true* or *false* and they don't need to be *sequential*, *orderly* or even *complete* to be valid; in fact, when dealing with a history stolen, in this case by Spanish conquistadores, fragmentation is pretty much inevitable.

This fragmentation aims to undercut the colonial record. Like Hak Kyung Cha, I use the blank spaces and a sometimes *jittery* layout of text to represent the parts of her identity that the archive could not (or would not) capture. *Citizen* explores the idea that violence often manifests through the mundane weight of repetition rather than isolated events. It is a system, after all.

This logic informed the visual representation of the Park section of Vol. 1 (p.16), which details the repetitive, strict protocol ruling social interaction.

Rankine's accumulation works through a specific mechanism: each micro-aggression reads as minor in isolation, but the sequential stacking makes the structural pattern undeniable. In the Park section mentioned above, this logic is rendered visually. The colonial voice lists the rules of conduct one after another in its rigid Courier typeface, each rule a seemingly reasonable regulation, until the sheer density of them reveals the system of control underneath. The repetition is the point.



3. POLYVOXIA

The complicated geometry of *Nimrods*

One key decision when devising this project was to develop a tripartite typographic system, or *polyvoxia*. This was inspired by Kawika Guillermo's ***Nimrods*** (2023), which blends poetry and prose so they merge into a single, cohesive current rather than existing as distinct, siloed sections. *Nimrods* proposes a break from traditional literary forms to express marginalized identities. In **Vol. 1, The Witness**, the typographic friction also illustrates and accentuates the complicated geometry of the road from violence to freedom:

- **The Voice of the Land (Fraunces typography):**
Rendered in Burnt Ochre, this voice represents the ancestral land of Chief Acserri; the people and ideas that come from there. It is organic and rounded, used for the word-portrait, the indigenous locations and their people, the 100-word pieces celebrating the lineage of Natacha and Zoe, and the struggle for freedom.
- **The Voice of the Colonial (Courier Prime typography):**
Rendered in Slate Blue, this rigid font mimics the logs of the settler state. It describes the rigid rules for interacting

in the park and highlights the words of oppression and segregation. It is an inverse reflection of the Voice of the Land; where the Land celebrates freedom and coming from one's origins, the Colonial fosters oppression and erasure.

- **The Voice of the Witness (Atkinson Hyperlegible typography):** This accessible sans-serif acts as the contemporary researcher, attempting to navigate the archive and narrating the story. They, however, are not an outside or objective observer; they try to tell the stories and weave ideas, both from the land and from the colonial, to record an archive that has risked erasure.

By refusing a single narrative voice, the project seeks to serve as a site of rebellion, language reclaiming, and rejection of normative structures.

The Voice of the Land

The Voice of the Colonial

The Voice of the Witness

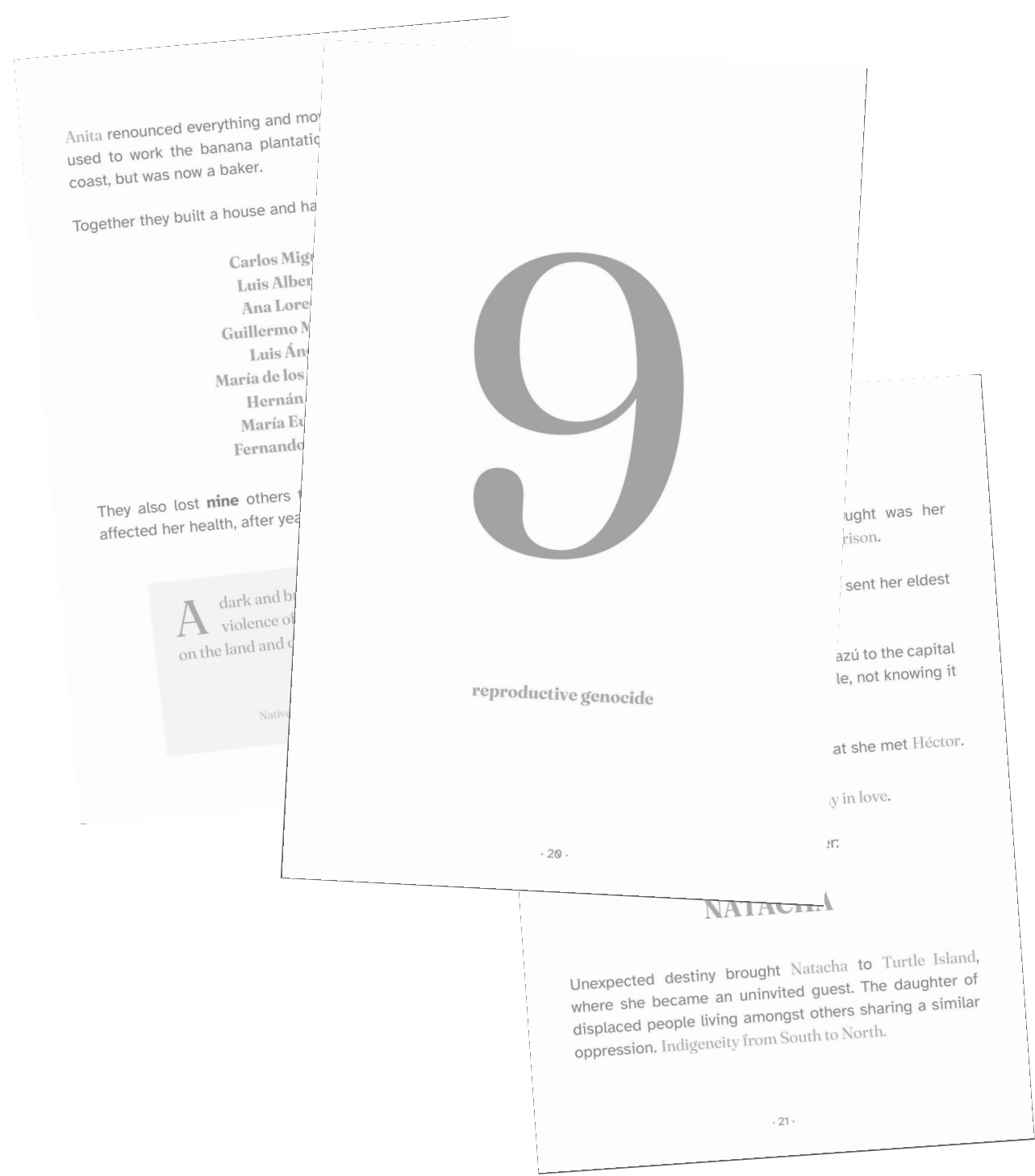
4. APPROACHING TRAUMA WITH TENDERNESS

Landbridge

Following Y-Dang Troeung's ***Landbridge*** (2024), I sought to present trauma but from a point of view of abundance; without playing the role of the victim and instead looking for authority. Troeung writes about cruelty but pairs it with love and care, suggesting that the latter makes the former bearable. In the zine, for example, I paired the horror of reproductive genocide with the continuity of life.

The “big 9” page, which represents the children Anita lost to poverty, paints a body at its limit. Yet it is accompanied with a photo of the sons who survived duress, and later with the description of Zoe, her great-granddaughter, as a “warm ray of sunshine turned human”. This contrast reveals the emotional landscape of resistance more effectively than direct description could; playing the role of a beaten-up victim ends up repeating the oppression of settler colonialism. In my work, the future-oriented descriptions of Zoe and Natacha provide that abundance, ensuring that the archive is not just a record of death, abuse and oppression, but a testament to the “eternal wild fire burning inside”, handed down for generations.

Closing with a photo of Zoe looking at Anita’s portrait on her altar is also intentional. In that way, the arc moves from loss to persistence to renewal, without the need of descriptions or explanations. It respects the readers *authory* and lets them put the parts together. Troeung’s framework helps articulate why this works: by refusing to dwell exclusively in the wound, the archive holds space for both grief and agency.



5. VISUAL METHODOLOGY

Yellow Rain and the *Indigenomicon*

The visual elements of Volume 1 are designed to look like “archival artifacts” through a somewhat brutalist aesthetic: raw, unadorned, visceral, organic. This was inspired by Mai Der Vang’s *Yellow Rain* (2021), which uses the viscosity of documents and white space to bear witness to Hmong history.

- **The ASCII Portrait:** Building a woman’s silhouette out of text fragments performs a visual recovery. Like Vang’s work, it suggests that the history of the “hidden” remains present within the very tools used to document their displacement.
- **The Indigenomicon Influence:** The mountain silhouettes were inspired by the world-building of the *Indigenomicon* (2023), where geography is not a backdrop but a character. The Topographic Spread (Pages 14–15) functions as a topographic palimpsest, where the *mirror* text floats over the slopes of Acserrí.

This visual methodology opposes the “clean” aesthetic of the colonial. The grainy-photocopy hillside on the covers, and the slightly misaligned spreads and visual elements

emphasize that testimonies do not need to be clean-cut or “objective” (whatever that word tries to mean) to be valid. In these ways, they also become acts of resistance (Ihmoud, 2025).



CONCLUSION

The Stories are Still Moving

In the Epilogue, I state that, as a witness, I tell these stories to honour the legacy of the women who endured against all odds. I emphasize that they are not the past; they are our present resistance. By saying their names and identifying their physical spaces, even when those names might seem insignificant, this archive ensures that the stories will keep moving. We continue to birth our people, even when humanity has failed. This project is my attempt to hold something I love and admire, this lineage, as an anchor used to remain present while navigating adversity.

The two volumes are in conversation with each other. Vol. 1 is the testimony; Vol. 2 is the reasoning behind it. Neither is complete without the other. *The Witness* holds the voices, the faces, the names. *The Critique* explains why those voices were designed the way they were, why fragmentation was chosen over linear narrative, why three typographies instead of one. Together, they form a single argument: that an Indigenous archive does not need institutional permission to exist, and that the act of making it is itself a form of resistance.

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Download this zine.

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